

A U.S. Field Guide to Employment, Work Exchange & Live-On-Site Opportunities

For people who need income and housing at the same time - including people relocating with very little money.

THE CORE IDEA

Instead of solving employment first and housing second, look for situations where the job itself solves part or all of the housing problem. Employer-provided housing can be a private apartment, cottage, cabin, bunkhouse, dorm room, RV site, trailer, staff housing, room in a private home, or discounted company housing.

IMPORTANT: This guide covers several different economic arrangements. Some are ordinary paid employment. Some provide wages plus housing. Some provide housing at a discounted cost. Some are work-for-housing arrangements with little or no cash pay. Others are volunteer/cultural exchanges. Read the compensation terms carefully before accepting anything.

CURRENTNESS: Individual jobs change constantly. The directories and search methods in this guide are designed to remain useful even after specific openings close. Always verify the current listing directly with the employer or host.

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1. UNDERSTAND THE SIX BASIC ARRANGEMENTS

PAID JOB + FREE HOUSING

You receive ordinary wages and the employer provides housing at no charge. This is the strongest economic arrangement when available.

PAID JOB + LOW-COST EMPLOYEE HOUSING

You earn wages but a fixed housing/meal amount is deducted from your paycheck or paid separately. Common in national parks, ski resorts and remote lodges.

PAID JOB + ON-SITE APARTMENT/COTTAGE AS PART OF COMPENSATION

Common with resident managers, property caretakers, self-storage managers, estate staff and some farm/ranch positions.

PART-TIME WORK IN EXCHANGE FOR HOUSING

You perform a defined number of hours for a room, cottage, RV site or apartment. Cash pay may be small or nonexistent.

ROOM + BOARD WORK EXCHANGE

Accommodation and food are exchanged for participation/help. WWOOF and many Workaway arrangements fall here. These are not automatically employment relationships.

VOLUNTEER/RESIDENT PROGRAM

A nonprofit, retreat center, camp or community may provide lodging and meals to resident volunteers. Stipends vary and some programs are unpaid.

2. FAST DECISION GUIDE: WHICH ROUTE FITS YOU?

Your situation	Best categories to search first	Why
Need cash pay AND housing	National park/resort, ranch, caregiver, resident manager, seasonal lodge	Most likely to combine a paycheck with housing.
Need housing immediately; cash pay is secondary	Caretaker, work exchange, WWOOF, campground host, retreat residency	Housing may be the primary compensation.
Have a child/dependent	Family housing resort jobs, WWOOF kid-friendly hosts, private caretaker cottage, family assistant, farm/homestead arrangements	Separate/private housing is more realistic than worker dorms.
No car	National parks/resorts with employee shuttles, live-in caregiving, resident management, urban household positions	Work and housing are together or transportation may be provided.
Want rural life	RanchWork, farms, WWOOF, caretaking, campground jobs	Housing is common because worksites are remote.
Want year-round stability	Resident property manager, storage manager, private estate caretaker, live-in caregiver, year-round ranch/farm	Less dependent on tourist seasons.
Can work seasonally	CoolWorks, Aramark	Large seasonal hiring

and relocate	Destinations, Delaware North, Xanterra, guest ranches, camps	pipelines regularly include housing.
Have little formal experience	Housekeeping, food service, campground cleaning, ranch hand, grounds, seasonal hospitality, farm exchange	Many openings emphasize reliability more than credentials.

3. NATIONAL PARKS, RESORTS, LODGES & CONCESSION JOBS

This is one of the largest established pipelines for jobs with employee housing. National parks themselves are federal lands, but many hotels, restaurants, stores, marinas and visitor services inside or near parks are operated by private concession companies.

Common jobs

Housekeeping / room attendant

Dishwasher / steward

Cook / prep cook

Restaurant server / host

Retail associate

Front desk / reservations

Laundry

Maintenance

Grounds

Transportation / shuttle driver

Marina or recreation staff

Security

Administrative roles

Supervisory/management roles

Housing usually looks like

Shared dormitory or staff housing

Shared cabin or apartment

Bunkhouse

Single room in some locations

Occasional family housing

Payroll-deducted housing and/or meal plan

Housing is often tied directly to employment. If the job ends, the right to remain in employee housing may end quickly, so always ask about move-out timing.

CoolWorks - Jobs With Housing: A major current directory dedicated to seasonal/outdoor employers that provide housing. At the time this guide was prepared, it listed hundreds of housing-provided employers. [Open website](#)

Aramark Destinations Careers: Search jobs at parks, lodges, resorts and marinas. Its current job search includes a 'Housing Available' field for eligible positions. [Open website](#)

Delaware North Parks & Resorts: Large national park/resort concession employer; its location pages identify properties where employee housing is available. [Open website](#)

Xanterra Travel Collection Careers: Major operator of national park lodges/resorts. Search individual properties and confirm housing details for each job. [Open website](#)

PROOF THAT FAMILY HOUSING EXISTS

Do not assume all resort housing is single-worker dorm housing. Some current CoolWorks employer profiles explicitly mark 'Family housing available: Yes.' Others restrict housing to single occupancy. Ask before applying if dependents matter.

4. CAMPGROUNDS, RV PARKS & CAMPGROUND HOSTING

Campground jobs can provide an RV site, hookups, cabin, staff housing, wages, or some combination. This can work particularly well for someone who already owns an RV, but private parks sometimes have employee cabins or trailers.

Search for

Campground host

Resident campground host

Work camper / workamper

Campground maintenance

RV park front desk

Campground housekeeping

Park store clerk

Reservation agent

Groundskeeper

Night host / security

Campground manager

Compensation patterns

Free RV site in exchange for a fixed number of hours

RV site + utilities + hourly pay after required hours

Hourly pay + discounted site

Free cabin/employee room + wages

Volunteer host site with no wages

Seasonal manager apartment/site

Workamper: Long-running work-camping employment/community source focused on jobs for people living in RVs or working at campgrounds and destination properties. [Open website](#)

CoolWorks: Search campgrounds, resorts and outdoor employers and use the housing filter/category. [Open website](#)

If you do NOT own an RV, search specifically for: 'campground host cabin provided', 'campground employee housing', 'resident campground manager apartment', and 'RV park job housing provided.'

5. RANCHES, GUEST RANCHES, HORSE FARMS & ANIMAL PROPERTIES

Rural ranch and equestrian employers often provide housing because commuting is difficult. Housing can range from shared bunkhouses to private cottages.

Jobs that may include housing

Ranch hand

Wrangler / trail guide

Housekeeper

Cook / kitchen staff

Maintenance technician

Caretaker

Property manager

Barn manager

Groom

Animal caretaker

Groundskeeper

Hunting/fishing guide support

Guest services

RanchWork - Jobs With Housing: Dedicated ranch/outdoor job board with a specific housing category. Current listings include ranch hands, property caretakers, cooks, wranglers and managers. [Open website](#)

RanchWork - Main Board: Broader ranch, farm, hunting, equestrian and outdoor employment listings. [Open website](#)

Current job boards show examples ranging from dorm-style housing to private cottages and housing-in-exchange-for-part-time-work. Treat each arrangement individually.

6. FARMS, ORGANIC AGRICULTURE & FARM APPRENTICESHIPS

Farm housing appears in three different forms: ordinary paid farm employment with housing; structured apprenticeships with housing/food/stipends; and educational work exchanges such as WWOOF.

Paid farm roles

Farm hand

Harvest worker

Greenhouse worker

Livestock caretaker

Dairy worker

Farm manager

Farm maintenance

CSA packing/delivery

Orchard/vineyard staff

Organic vegetable production

Apprenticeship roles

Apprenticeships may combine instruction, work, food, housing and a stipend. Read the hours and compensation carefully; 'internship' does not automatically mean paid.

ATTRA Sustainable Agriculture Internship/Apprenticeship Listings: National sustainable agriculture network where farms post internships, apprenticeships and related opportunities. [Open website](#)

WWOOF USA: Organic farm exchange network. Hosts provide accommodations and food/learning in exchange for farm participation. WWOOF is generally not a cash-paying job. [Open website](#)

WWOOF USA says its host search can be filtered by lodging, stay length and kid-friendly farms. Its published family guidance reports hundreds of U.S. hosts that welcome adults traveling with children.

7. PROPERTY CARETAKERS, ESTATE CARETAKERS & LAND STEWARDS

This category is especially important because the housing often already exists: guest cottage, caretaker house, ranch apartment, cabin, trailer or separate unit.

Typical duties

Live on property and maintain a visible presence

Open/close buildings

Receive deliveries and contractors

Basic grounds work

Feed animals

Pool/property checks

Minor maintenance

Coordinate vendors

Housekeeping

Mail handling

Garden care

Security observation

Prepare property before owners arrive

Search terms

property caretaker housing provided

estate caretaker cottage

live-in property caretaker

resident groundskeeper

land steward housing

farm caretaker cabin

private estate caretaker

houseman housing provided

The Caretaker Gazette: Long-running publication specializing in caretaking, property sitting, house sitting, farms, ranches, estates, inns and other live-on-site arrangements. Full listing access may require a subscription. [Open website](#)

RanchWork Caretaker/Housing Jobs: Useful for rural caretaker and ranch caretaker roles. [Open website](#)

8. RESIDENT APARTMENT / PROPERTY MANAGERS

Apartment communities, manufactured-home communities and other residential properties sometimes employ an on-site or resident manager and provide a unit or housing discount.

Typical duties

Leasing/showings

Collecting rents

Resident communication

Move-in/move-out inspections

Emergency contact duties

Light maintenance coordination

Vendor access

Property walks

Office/admin work

After-hours response

Search: 'resident manager apartment included', 'on-site property manager housing', 'apartment manager free apartment', 'property manager paid housing', and 'manufactured home community resident manager.'

These roles can be highly suitable for year-round housing, but some employers require prior leasing/property-management experience and may require you to be on call.

9. SELF-STORAGE RESIDENT MANAGERS

Some self-storage facilities employ live-on-site managers. Current listings still exist for resident self-storage property managers with private apartments included, although some explicitly limit occupancy to one person.

Typical duties

Rent storage units

Take payments

Answer calls

Sell locks/insurance/add-ons

Property walks

Maintain cleanliness

Coordinate repairs

Handle delinquency notices

Open/close gates or office

Basic sales and customer service

Search: 'self storage resident manager apartment', 'live on site storage manager', 'storage property manager apartment provided'.

DEPENDENT WARNING

A job can include a full apartment but still prohibit partners or children. Current resident-storage listings sometimes say 'single occupancy only.' Never infer that an apartment automatically means family housing.

10. MOTELS, INNS, HOSTELS & SMALL HOSPITALITY PROPERTIES

Small independent hospitality businesses sometimes solve staffing shortages by housing employees on-site. The arrangements are often less standardized than major hotel chains.

Possible roles

Resident motel manager

Night manager

Front desk + housekeeping

Innkeeper

Assistant innkeeper

Hostel manager

Maintenance + guest services

Housekeeper with room

Property caretaker

Breakfast/kitchen attendant

Search individual independent motels/inns in lower-cost regions and look for 'resident manager,' 'manager apartment,' 'live-in innkeeper,' 'housing provided,' and 'on-site accommodation.'

Because informal properties may not advertise widely, direct outreach can work: ask whether they employ any resident manager, caretaker or multi-role staff and whether an unused room/apartment can be part of compensation.

11. LIVE-IN CAREGIVER & COMPANION POSITIONS

Live-in care ranges from medical/high-assistance work requiring credentials to nonmedical companionship and household help. Do not accept duties beyond your training.

Nonmedical companion work may include

Companionship

Meal preparation

Light housekeeping

Medication reminders (not administration unless legally appropriate/trained)

Errands

Laundry

Walking/activities

Scheduling

Pet/plant care

Being present overnight

Housing may be

Private bedroom in client's home

Private bedroom + bathroom

In-law suite

Guesthouse

Separate apartment

Room plus meals

Care.com - Senior Care / Live-In Caregiver Jobs: Private families and care clients post companion and caregiving positions; verify duties, credentials, hours, housing and whether dependents are permitted. [Open website](#)

Search: 'live-in companion private room', 'senior companion room and board', 'live-in caregiver private apartment', 'resident companion', 'private duty live-in caregiver'.

If you are expected to remain available during sleep/off-duty periods, clarify exactly which hours are working time, on-call time and truly free time.

12. NANNY, FAMILY ASSISTANT & HOUSEHOLD STAFF

Private households sometimes hire live-in nannies, family assistants, housekeepers, cooks, personal assistants and household managers.

Potential roles

Live-in nanny

Family assistant

Mother's helper

Housekeeper

Housekeeper/cook

Household assistant

Personal assistant

Estate housekeeper

Household manager

Domestic couple (two-person role)

Housing may be a bedroom in the family home, separate staff quarters, guesthouse or apartment. Families seeking highly experienced private-service staff may demand references and background checks; family-assistant or helper positions can be more accessible.

Search both mainstream job boards and private-service staffing agencies using 'live-in,' 'housing provided,' 'private apartment,' 'staff cottage' and 'family assistant.'

13. RETREAT CENTERS, CAMPS, SPIRITUAL CENTERS & CONFERENCE PROPERTIES

These properties often possess the thing most employers do not: many beds or cabins. They may hire residential staff because they are rural and operate around the clock.

Roles

Kitchen

Housekeeping

Grounds

Garden

Maintenance

Guest services

Program support

Office/admin

Marketing/social media

Retreat operations

Resident steward

Volunteer/residency coordinator

Search terms: 'retreat center residential staff', 'resident volunteer room board', 'retreat center housing provided', 'conference center employee housing', 'spiritual center work exchange', 'resident steward'.

Some programs are true paid employment; others are room-and-board residency programs. Confirm which before traveling.

14. OUTDOOR EDUCATION, ENVIRONMENTAL PROGRAMS & YOUTH CAMPS

Summer camps, outdoor schools and environmental centers routinely house seasonal staff because programs operate in rural locations.

Roles beyond being a counselor

Kitchen

Housekeeping

Maintenance

Office/registration

Arts/crafts

Outdoor instruction

Farm/garden educator

Driver

Health office support where qualified

Media/photo/video

Program logistics

Occupation Wild - Jobs With Housing: Outdoor-industry job board with a dedicated housing-provided page, including camps, field instructor programs, resorts and seasonal outdoor work. [Open website](#)

CoolWorks: Also lists summer camps, conference centers, nonprofit outdoor programs and similar employers with staff housing. [Open website](#)

Caution for parents: staff housing is frequently shared and may not allow dependents. Ask before applying.

15. MARINAS, FISHING LODGES, WILDERNESS OPERATIONS & REMOTE TOURISM

Remote employers often provide housing because there is nowhere nearby to rent. Alaska is especially prominent, but opportunities exist nationwide.

Fishing lodge staff

Dock/marina staff

Deckhand

Housekeeping

Cook

Maintenance

Guide support

Remote lodge front desk

Boat cleaning

Guest services

Wilderness camp staff

Housing may be remote bunkhouses or cabins and may include meals. Ask about transportation to the worksite, cellular/Wi-Fi access, medical access, pay schedule, and return transportation when the season ends.

16. WORKAWAY, WWOOF, HELPX & OTHER WORK-EXCHANGE ROUTES

These can solve housing temporarily, but they are not automatically jobs. The host may provide room/food in exchange for agreed help. Treat them as a separate category from wage employment.

Workaway: Hosts include farms, families, communities, hostels, nonprofits, sustainable projects, house/pet sitting and more. Messaging hosts requires membership. [Open website](#)

WWOOF USA: Organic farm exchanges; host search includes lodging and kid-friendly filters. WWOOF states that many hosts welcome adults traveling with children. [Open website](#)

HelpX: Host-help exchange directory for farms, homestays, hostels and similar arrangements. [Open website](#)

Permies: Large permaculture/homesteading community forum where people post landmate, work-trade, caretaker and community opportunities. [Open website](#)

Before accepting an exchange

Exact work hours per day/week

Exact accommodation - private or shared

Food included or not

Wi-Fi/cell service

Laundry

Transportation

Length of stay

Child/dependent policy

Days off

Whether paid work is also available

What happens if either side ends the arrangement early

17. HOUSE SITTING & PROPERTY SITTING

House sitting can reduce housing costs while you care for a home, pets or property. Most mainstream house-sitting platforms are exchanges rather than paid employment, and memberships may cost money.

Longer rural sits can function as a temporary landing arrangement, but never rely on one without confirmed dates, written expectations and a backup plan. Search for 'long-term house sitter,' 'property sitter,' 'farm sitter,' and 'estate sitter.'

Caretaker jobs are usually better than ordinary house sitting when you need both housing and ongoing income.

18. HOUSING OPTIONS THAT ARE NOT CASH COMPENSATION

A housing benefit can take several forms. Ask the employer to state exactly which one applies.

Free room

Free apartment

Private cottage

Shared employee housing

Discounted employee apartment

RV site only

RV site + electric/water/sewer

Dorm/bunkhouse

Meals included

Housing deducted from paycheck

Housing credit counted toward wages

Temporary housing only during the season

Never evaluate an offer from the phrase 'housing provided' alone.

19. APPLYING WITH A CHILD, PARTNER OR DEPENDENT

Dependents change the search, but do not automatically eliminate it. The goal is to target housing structures that can legally and practically accommodate more than one person.

Prioritize

Private apartment

Private cottage/cabin

Guesthouse

Family employee housing

Farm/homestead family hosts

Caretaker residence

Live-in family assistant with separate quarters

Year-round resident manager units with permitted family occupancy

Usually harder

Seasonal dorms

Bunkhouses

Shared staff cabins

Single-occupancy storage-manager apartments

Live-in caregiver bedroom in client's home

Remote field camps

Ask BEFORE completing a long application: 'I would be relocating with one dependent child/partner. Does the housing attached to this position permit dependents, and if so, what type of unit is available?'

WWOOF USA publicly states that hundreds of its hosts are kid-friendly; Workaway also has family-hosting categories. Individual hosts still set their own rules.

20. APPLYING WHEN YOU HAVE NO RENTAL HISTORY

Employer housing often does not function like a conventional apartment application. The employer may care more about employment eligibility, references, background checks and job fit than landlord history.

Ask whether housing requires a separate lease/application.

Ask whether a credit check is run for employee housing.

Ask whether a deposit is required.

Ask whether prior rental references are required.

Keep employment references even if you lack landlord references.

If housing is on private property, ask whether occupancy is contingent solely on employment.

Do not assume 'housing provided' means no screening. Some employers run full background checks; others do not.

21. APPLYING WITHOUT A CAR

A housing-included job can be ideal without a vehicle because the workplace and housing are often together. But transportation to groceries, doctors and the nearest town still matters.

Does the employer pick workers up from the nearest bus/train/airport?

Is there an employee shuttle?

Are meals provided?

Is there a staff store?

Can groceries be delivered?

How far is the nearest pharmacy/medical clinic?

Is employee housing walkable to the job?

How do employees leave the property on days off?

If the job ends, how do you get back to an intercity transportation hub?

22. WHAT TO ASK BEFORE ACCEPTING HOUSING

What is the hourly wage/salary/stipend?

How many guaranteed hours per week?

Is overtime available or required?

Is housing free, discounted or deducted from wages?

What is the exact housing cost per week/paycheck?

Are utilities included?

Are meals included or deducted?

Is the room private or shared?

How many people share the bathroom/kitchen?

Can a child/partner/dependent live there?

Is there a housing deposit?

Is there a separate lease or occupancy agreement?

What are the move-in and move-out dates?

How soon must I leave if employment ends?

Is there Wi-Fi?

Is cellular service reliable?

Is laundry available?

Can I receive mail/packages?

Can I cook my own food?

Is there refrigeration?

Are pets allowed?

Is transportation to town provided?

Is there public transportation?

Can I see current photos or do a video tour of the housing?

Can I speak with a current employee about the housing?

What identification/background screening is required?

When is the first paycheck?

What amount of money should I arrive with?

Who pays travel costs?

Do you reimburse travel after a certain period?

23. CALCULATE THE REAL VALUE OF THE OFFER

Housing is valuable only if you understand what it replaces and what it costs.

SIMPLE COMPARISON

Monthly cash pay + value of housing + included meals/utilities - housing deductions - meal deductions - transportation costs - required fees = practical compensation.

Example: a lower-wage resort job with a \$300/month room, meals and transportation may leave more usable income than a higher-wage urban job requiring \$1,300 rent plus utilities and commuting.

Questions that change the math

Do you get 40 hours or only 20?

Is housing \$0 or \$600/month?

Are meals mandatory deductions?

Do you need Uber to buy groceries?

Is the housing furnished?

Do you need a deposit?

Does the employer pay/reimburse travel?

Can you stay year-round?

Can you keep housing during days off or gaps between seasons?

24. LABOR RIGHTS WHEN HOUSING IS PART OF COMPENSATION

Federal wage law can allow an employer, under certain circumstances, to count the reasonable cost or fair value of lodging toward minimum-wage obligations. This does not mean an employer can assign any arbitrary value to poor housing.

U.S. Department of Labor guidance says that, when an employer uses the federal FLSA Section 3(m) lodging credit, conditions include voluntary acceptance, compliance with applicable federal/state/local housing laws, primary benefit to the employee, and accurate records. The allowable credit cannot exceed applicable reasonable cost/fair-value limits.

[U.S. Department of Labor - Lodging Credit Guidance](#)

State wage laws may provide additional protections. If something feels wrong, preserve the job posting, offer letter, housing agreement, pay stubs, time records and messages.

Housing tied to employment creates leverage

If losing your job also means immediately losing your bed, the employer has unusual power over you. Get the termination/move-out rules in writing before relocating. Local landlord/tenant protections vary depending on how the housing is structured.

25. SCAM & EXPLOITATION WARNING SIGNS

Housing-included opportunities are extremely attractive to people in urgent situations, which also makes them attractive bait for scammers or exploitative hosts.

They demand money to 'secure' a job.

They send a check and instruct you to buy equipment or send part of the money elsewhere.

Recruiting happens only through unsolicited text/WhatsApp/Telegram with no verifiable company process.

The property/employer cannot be independently verified.

They refuse a video interview or refuse to show the housing.

They will not state working hours in writing.

They advertise 'free housing' but expect 24/7 availability.

They want possession of your ID/passport.

They prohibit you from leaving the property during off-hours.

They refuse to explain how/when you are paid.

The housing is unsafe, illegal, overcrowded or lacks basic sanitation.

The role suddenly changes after arrival.

They pressure you to travel before an offer or housing details are confirmed.

They ask for bank passwords, PINs, gift cards, crypto or upfront 'training' payments.

They require you to receive and reship packages purchased by unknown people.

The FTC warns that legitimate employers do not require you to pay to get a job and warns against fake-check and reshipping job scams.

[FTC - Job Scams](#)

26. SEARCH TERMS THAT UNCOVER HIDDEN OPPORTUNITIES

GENERAL

jobs with housing provided

jobs with room and board

employee housing provided

live on site jobs

resident jobs housing included

work for housing

housing included employment

PRIVATE PROPERTY

property caretaker housing provided

estate caretaker cottage

live-in caretaker private apartment

resident groundskeeper

land steward housing

farm caretaker cabin

HOSPITALITY

resident motel manager

innkeeper housing provided

hostel manager accommodation

lodge jobs housing provided

resort employee housing

RURAL / FARM

farm jobs housing provided

ranch hand housing

horse farm live-in job

farm apprenticeship housing stipend

organic farm housing provided

FAMILY / DEPENDENTS

family housing provided jobs

employee housing family allowed

caretaker cottage family

jobs with housing dependents allowed

farm job family housing

CAREGIVING / HOUSEHOLD

live-in companion private apartment

live-in caregiver room board

family assistant housing provided

live-in housekeeper apartment

household assistant staff cottage

CAMPGROUND

campground host housing

campground host cabin provided

workamper wages site

RV park manager apartment

campground employee housing

PROPERTY MANAGEMENT

resident apartment manager housing

on-site property manager apartment

self storage resident manager apartment

mobile home park manager housing

RETREAT / COMMUNITY

retreat center residential staff

resident volunteer room board

retreat caretaker housing

spiritual center work exchange

conference center staff housing

27. NATIONWIDE JOB BOARDS & DIRECTORIES

CoolWorks - Jobs With Housing: Best broad starting point for resorts, parks, camps, lodges, ranches, nonprofits and seasonal/outdoor employers. [Open website](#)

Occupation Wild - Jobs With Housing: Outdoor, camp, environmental, resort and adventure work with housing. [Open website](#)

RanchWork - Housing Jobs: Ranches, horse properties, caretakers, cooks, ranch hands, wranglers and rural properties. [Open website](#)

ATTRA Internships: Sustainable farms, agriculture apprenticeships and training opportunities. [Open website](#)

Caretaker Gazette: Property, estate, farm, ranch, inn and house-sitting/caretaking opportunities; some content is subscription-based. [Open website](#)

Workamper: Campgrounds, RV parks and work-camping arrangements. [Open website](#)

WWOOF USA: Organic farm room/food exchange; use kid-friendly and lodging filters where relevant. [Open website](#)

Workaway: Work exchange, families, communities, hostels, farms, pet/house sitting and other host arrangements; membership required to message. [Open website](#)

HelpX: Work-exchange host directory. [Open website](#)

Care.com: Private family caregiving, companion care and household work; search live-in roles. [Open website](#)

Aramark Destinations: National parks, hotels, resorts and marinas; current search displays housing availability on eligible jobs. [Open website](#)

Delaware North Parks & Resorts: National park/resort employment with location-specific employee housing information. [Open website](#)

Xanterra Careers: Major national-park/resort concession employer. [Open website](#)

USAJobs: Federal jobs. Housing is not generally included, but remote/park positions may have quarters or special arrangements described in individual announcements. [Open website](#)

28. A 48-HOUR SEARCH STRATEGY

HOURL 1: Define your non-negotiables

Must have cash pay?

Minimum weekly income?

Need child/dependent housing?

Private room required?

Wi-Fi required?

No car?

How far can you relocate?

Earliest travel date?

Can you do physical labor?

Can you work nights/weekends?

HOURS 2-4: Open six pipelines

CoolWorks

RanchWork

ATTRA

Caretaker Gazette/public caretaker searches

Care.com/live-in roles

Workaway/WWOOF/Permies if work exchange is acceptable

DAY 1: Build a 20-lead sheet

Record: employer/host, location, job, pay, housing type, housing cost, child policy, transportation, contact method, date applied, response.

DAY 2: Contact the best 10 directly

Prioritize listings that explicitly mention housing rather than applying broadly to jobs where housing is unknown. Ask the dependent/transportation questions immediately when relevant.

Do not spend travel money until

You know the employer/host's real identity.

You have confirmed the physical location.

You know exactly where you will sleep.

You have confirmed the start date.

You know the money required on arrival.

You have a written or saved copy of the job/arrangement.

You have a fallback if the arrangement fails.

29. APPLICATION & OUTREACH TEMPLATES

Short inquiry before applying

Hello, I'm interested in the [position]. Before I complete the full application, could you confirm the housing arrangement? I would be relocating from out of area. Is housing available for this position, what does it cost, and is it private or shared? [If applicable: I would be relocating with one dependent child/partner; does the employee housing permit dependents?] Thank you.

Caretaker / unusual direct outreach

Hello, I'm reaching out because I saw your property/business and wanted to ask whether you ever hire resident caretakers, property assistants, grounds/household help, or other live-on-site staff. I am specifically looking for a longer-term arrangement where housing is part of compensation. I can help with [relevant skills]. If you have a cottage, apartment, cabin, room or other on-site housing attached to a role, I'd be interested in discussing what you need.

Farm / homestead inquiry

Hello, I'm looking for a residential farm or homestead position/apprenticeship and am interested in [gardening, animals,

herbs, food production, maintenance, etc.]. I'm open to a combination of paid work and housing or a clearly defined work-exchange arrangement. Could you tell me what accommodation is available, expected hours, whether food is included, and the expected length of stay?

Follow-up after receiving an offer

Thank you. Before I arrange transportation, could you please confirm in writing: start date, hourly pay/stipend, expected weekly hours, housing type, housing cost/deductions, utilities/meals included, move-in date, and how long I may remain in housing if the position ends? I also want to confirm [dependent/transportation/Wi-Fi requirement].

30. BEFORE-YOU-TRAVEL VERIFICATION CHECKLIST

- ☐ Employer/host independently verified
- ☐ Real street address confirmed
- ☐ Phone/video conversation completed
- ☐ Job title and duties confirmed
- ☐ Cash pay confirmed
- ☐ Hours confirmed
- ☐ Pay schedule confirmed
- ☐ Housing type confirmed
- ☐ Current housing photos/video seen
- ☐ Housing cost confirmed
- ☐ Deposit confirmed
- ☐ Utilities confirmed
- ☐ Meals confirmed
- ☐ Wi-Fi/cell service confirmed
- ☐ Child/dependent permission confirmed if needed
- ☐ Move-in date confirmed
- ☐ Move-out rule if job ends confirmed
- ☐ Transportation from bus/train/airport confirmed
- ☐ Grocery access confirmed
- ☐ Medical/pharmacy access confirmed
- ☐ First-paycheck timing confirmed
- ☐ Money needed on arrival calculated
- ☐ Backup place to sleep identified
- ☐ Important documents kept with you, not surrendered
- ☐ Offer/listing/screenshots saved offline

FINAL PRINCIPLE

THE JOB IS NOT JUST THE PAYCHECK

When money is limited, the most valuable job may be the one that simultaneously provides income, shelter, utilities, meals, transportation or community access. Compare the full survival package - not just the hourly wage. But never trade urgency for safety: verify the employer, understand the housing, keep control of your identification and money, and know what happens if the job ends.

SOURCE NOTES & OFFICIAL REFERENCES

[CoolWorks Jobs With Housing](#)

[Aramark Destinations Careers](#)

[Delaware North Parks & Resorts](#)

[RanchWork Jobs With Housing](#)

[WWOOF USA Kid-Friendly WWOOFing](#)

[U.S. Department of Labor - FLSA lodging credit guidance](#)

[FTC - Job Scams](#)